

THE ALTAR

Ara



SIZE RANKING 63

BRIGHTEST STARS Alpha (α) 2.8, Beta (β) 2.8

GENITIVE Arae

ABBREVIATION Ara

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM June–July

FULLY VISIBLE 22°N–90°S



Ara was visualized by the ancient Greeks as the altar on which the gods of Olympus swore an oath of allegiance before their battle with the Titans for control of the universe (see

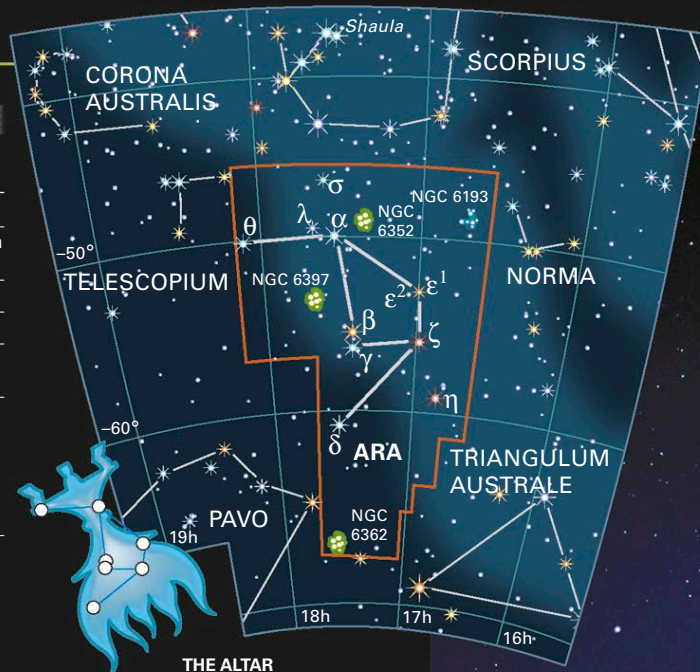
MYTHS AND STORIES

TITANOMACHIA

Titanomachia, or the Clash of the Titans, was the 10-year war for dominance of the universe between the gods on Mount Olympus, led by Zeus, and the Titans on Mount Othrys. In gratitude for their victory, Zeus placed the altar of the gods in the sky.

VICTORY PANEL

Part of the battle of the gods and Titans is here depicted in the Zeus Altar of Pergamon, which was sculpted in Greece c. 180 BCE.



THE ALTAR

panel, left). This southern constellation lies within the Milky Way and is situated south of Scorpius.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

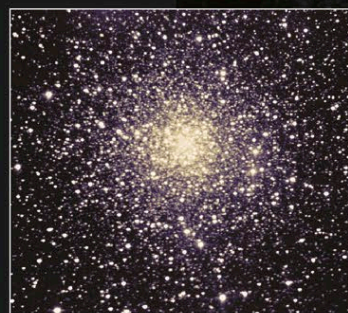
The attractive open cluster NGC 6193 consists of about 30 stars of 6th magnitude and fainter. It can be viewed through binoculars.

NGC 6397 is among the closest globular clusters to us, being around 10,000 light-years away, and can be seen well through binoculars or a small telescope. Like NGC 6193, it appears relatively large—both being over half the apparent width of a full moon.

Ara contains no stars of particular interest to users of small telescopes.

NGC 6397

The globular cluster NGC 6397 has a condensed center and scattered outer regions in which chains and sprays of stars can be traced.



INCENSE BURNER

Ara, the celestial altar, is oriented with its top facing south. Incense burning on the altar might give off the “smoke” of the Milky Way above it.

THE SOUTHERN CROWN

Corona Australis



SIZE RANKING 80

BRIGHTEST STARS Alpha (α) 4.1, Beta (β) 4.1

GENITIVE Coronae Australis

ABBREVIATION CrA

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM July–August

FULLY VISIBLE 44°N–90°S



The small southern constellation of Corona Australis lies under the feet of Sagittarius. It comprises stars of 4th magnitude and fainter, and it was one of the 48 constellations recognized by the ancient Greek astronomer Ptolemy (see p.347).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

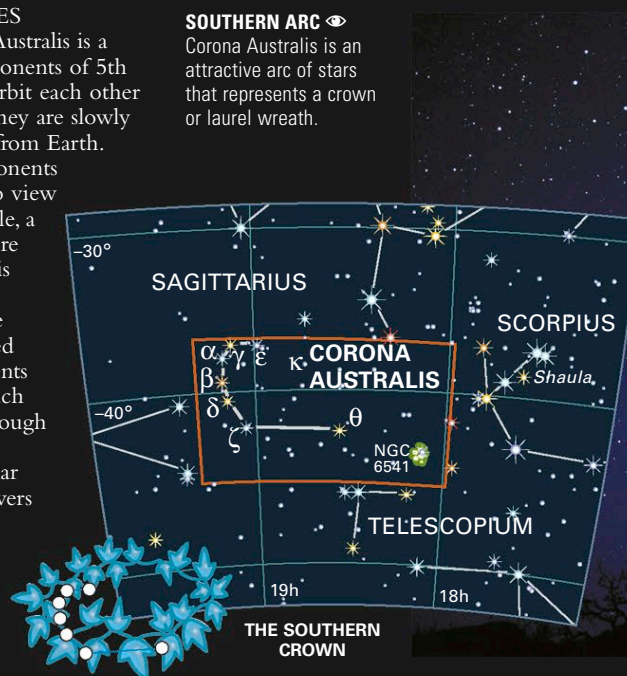
Gamma (γ) Coronae Australis is a binary star with components of 5th magnitude. The pair orbit each other every 122 years, and they are slowly moving apart as seen from Earth. This means the components are becoming easier to view individually. Meanwhile, a 4-in (100-mm) aperture is needed to divide this challenging star.

Kappa (κ) Coronae Australis is an unrelated double with components of 6th magnitude, which are readily divided through a small telescope.

The modest globular cluster NGC 6541 covers about one-third the apparent diameter of a full moon. It is visible through a small telescope or binoculars.

SOUTHERN ARC

Corona Australis is an attractive arc of stars that represents a crown or laurel wreath.



THE SOUTHERN CROWN